

The Half-Mask Shrine

Tier	Tier 2
Party Level	5 PCs at Level 5 (advance to 6 on completion)
Duration	~3.5–4 hours of play
Setting	Old Skull's northern flank — Hawthorn Chimney (collapsed) → the granite shoulder → Site C
Hook From	Session 002 — <i>The Second Cleft</i> (Site B closed; Site C still open)



Adventure Summary

Site B is rubble. Site C is not. The party wakes at the collapsed Hawthorn Chimney with the smell of cold ash on their bedrolls and a four-hour traverse of granite shoulder ahead of them. At the cleft they meet two unexpected things — a drow watcher in a pine with a brass horn at her belt, and a curious pixie named **Quillip Burr-and-Whistle** who has been counting watch rotations from a knothole for two days and is willing to trade her notes for the right kind of fey-style payment.

Inside the cleft is the same shrine-camp from last session's intelligence: an antechamber with two scouts, a spider pen, and a shrine where **Khelziir Aun'velve** stands at the basalt altar mid-ritual, with **Zeldrazz T'orrl** flanking him. The ritual countdown is now **two rounds** — the priest has had an extra night to work. And somewhere on round four, if the party stalls, a **Lolthite raid party** comes up the Underdark passage and crashes the shrine from behind.

The session ends with the portal anchor either smashed, stolen for study, or — if the party is clever enough to leave it running — turned into a one-way Harper listening glyph. Then the party walks back to Shadowdale and reports to Brynn or Orvyn first, and Lady Ulphor tells them what it cost her to put Captain Helm back together.

Scene 1 — Cold Camp at the Hawthorn Chimney

Setup

Dawn. Pale light through the hawthorn boughs at Site B. The cleft is collapsed (the drider's death-throes from last session, plus the Lolthite charges that purged the camp), and a film of mist clings to the granite. The party slept here on the assumption that nobody would come looking for them in the wreckage of someone else's purge. They were right. Now it's morning.

The hawthorn berries above you are pale as dead pearls. The cleft mouth is gone — twenty feet of granite collapsed in on itself, the chimney throat sealed. Three of your bedrolls are scattered around a fire pit that didn't get lit last night. The wind smells of cold stone and, faintly, of something that was burning two days ago and isn't anymore.

What This Scene Is For

- An inventory beat after a long rest. **Yinu has all spell slots back.** Anyone who burned daily resources at Site B is fresh. Make sure that lands.
- **Brynn's letter.** Loric finds a folded paper tucked into his pack he doesn't remember packing. It is in Brynn Ashford's hand, sealed with the thistle-and-ash sigil of Shadowdale. *"Whatever you find at the third site, I want a sketch and a number before Orvyn does. I am not asking you to lie to him. I am asking you to choose the door you knock on first."* No signature. The letter is Loric's to share, sit on, or burn.
- **Decision beat.** Push for Site C now (4 hr overland) or scout the surrounding granite for any Lolthite track-sign. Either choice is fine; the Northern Traverse skill check in Scene 2 takes the choice into account.

DM Notes — Cold Camp Tone

- Yinu's *Fireball* exhaustion from last session is fully recovered after the long rest. No mechanical penalty.
- **Aelinor Wains has retired** — the militia reserve is unavailable this session. Corwick said no, and Lady Ulphor agreed. The party is alone on the granite.
- Don't push the letter. If Loric pockets it without comment, that's also a story.

Scene 2 — The Northern Traverse

The Trek

Approximately four hours overland from the collapsed Site B to the cleft mouth on Old Skull's northern flank. The route skirts the granite shoulder above the Living Wood — windier, colder, and more exposed than the southern approach last session. No fey wards to navigate up here; the Living Wood thins out before the bare stone.

Skill Check — Pathfinding

A single **Survival or Nature DC 13** check, made by the lead PC. (No skill challenge — this is a transition, not a setpiece.)

- **Success:** the party arrives at the cleft mouth in early afternoon, with daylight and time to scout.
- **Failure:** they arrive at dusk, footsore. Each PC starts the next encounter at half their hit-dice pool unless they short-rest at the cleft (which Khelziir's spider will hear).

Optional — Lolthite Track-Sign

Anyone who *additionally* takes a **DC 14 Survival** check on the way up may notice three sets of overlapping scuff-marks in the lichen on a granite ledge — boot-edges, recent, moving *uphill* and *toward Site C from a different angle than the party*. This is the **only forewarning** of the Lolthite Crash later. If the party flags it, they may set up watchposts, leave a trip-wire, or simply mention it to Quillip. If they miss it, the Crash arrives with full surprise.

DM Notes — Traverse Tone

- Quiet and exposed. No combat. Use this scene for character beats — Brynn's letter, Yinu's spellbook, Fiorn cracking up the marching order.
- If the party has a Druid, Nalith may notice the wood is *too* quiet on the northern shoulder. The fey have withdrawn here as well — confirm Sela Wyndmere's report.

Scene 3 — The Watcher Above & The Knothole

The Cleft Mouth

The same cleft mouth from last session's intelligence. A vertical fissure 6 ft. wide and 10 ft. tall in the granite shoulder, breathing cold spider-musk air. Spider-silk threads still cross the opening at ankle and chest height — Khelziir's tripwire chime.

Encounter — The Watcher

A single **Drow Scout** is perched in a wind-stunted pine sixty feet above the cleft mouth, brass signal horn slung at her belt. **DC 17 Perception** to spot her before she spots the party. If she sees them first, she **blows the horn before being killed** — Khelziir's cell goes to alert and the antechamber loses its surprise round.

The Pixie in the Knothole

Lower on the same pine, in a knothole the size of a thumb-tip, **Quillip Burr-and-Whistle** has been hiding for two days, taking pinecone-stack notes on Khelziir's cell. She is invisible by default. She **reveals herself the moment a PC says or does something interesting** — Druidic spoken aloud (Nalith), a shapechange (Fiorn), a true name, a fragment of a real song, an honest greeting addressed to the empty pine.

Quillip's Bargain

Once visible, Quillip introduces herself in rhyming couplets and offers a deal. She'll trade **one** of the following for **one** fey-style payment:

Offering	What It Does
Intel	Watch rotations, the spider's alarm-shriek behavior, Khelziir's mid-ritual status, Zeldrazz's position. Removes the antechamber's surprise penalty even if the horn sounds.
Diversion	Quillip casts <i>phantasmal force</i> and lures the Watcher down the trunk to an empty hollow. The Watcher is removed from the encounter without a horn-blow.
Banked Boon	A single-use casting of one of <i>polymorph</i> , <i>confusion</i> , or <i>sleep</i> (Quillip's choice from the three named) on a target the party identifies within 24 hours. She arrives invisibly and casts on cue.

What She'll Accept as Payment

- A **true secret** about a PC, told plainly (the secret must be one Quillip couldn't easily learn elsewhere)
- A **song** never sung in the Living Wood before (Fiorn or Nalith — Performance check is roleplay, not a die roll)
- A **true name** offered freely — the giver's, or a known third party's
- A **page from Yinu's spellbook**, copied for her in fresh ink (one cantrip or one 1st-level spell — Quillip won't read magic, she just likes the shapes)
- A **binding promise** — "*Speak my name aloud the next time you stand under a hawthorn*" or similar fey-style geas; cost comes due exactly as stated
- A **token from far away** — anything from outside the Dales the party has carried with them

Bargain Rules (DM)

- All bargains are honored fey-style. The boon arrives reliably; the cost comes due exactly as stated, no twist. **Quillip is not a hag.**
- If the party stiffes her, she returns in a later session demanding payment with interest. Do not skip this.
- If brushed off or threatened, she vanishes (Superior Invisibility). She will **not** tip off the Vhaeraunians — drow are distasteful to her — but the offered intel and boon are gone for this session.
- **She will go very still and leave the conversation** if asked directly about Sela Wyndmere's "unnamed fey lord." Don't volunteer this; only react if the party probes it.

Approach Options to the Cleft (Once the Watcher Is Handled)

- **Frontal stealth** — group Stealth DC 13 to enter without triggering the silk
- **Cut the wires** — Sleight of Hand DC 12 to cut without ringing the chime
- **Climb above** — DC 15 Athletics, drops party into the antechamber from the ceiling (no silk, surprise round if quiet)

Scene 4 — The Antechamber

Chamber 1 — The Antechamber

A 30 × 30 ft. natural cavern with two bedroll piles, a cookfire smoldering in the center, and a weapon rack against the east wall holding three hand crossbows and a sheaf of bolts. **2× Drow Scouts** are on watch — one fletching, one dozing.

- If the party kept surprise (or bought it from Quillip), both can drop in the first round.
- If the horn sounded, both are crossbow-ready and one will sprint for the Shrine to warn Khelziir on initiative count 10.
- The cookfire is **lit and tended** — kicking it over scatters embers and opens line of sight from the antechamber into the Spider Pen's silk curtain (Scene 5).

What the Antechamber Tells the Party

- The two scouts are wearing **standard Vhaeraun half-masks**. Khelziir's silver one is in the Shrine. The reinforcements that step through the portal (if it opens) wear plain black — they're not from this cell.
- One bedroll has a journal in Undercommon: a **two-day count of attempts to consecrate the anchor**. Yinu can read it (Arcana DC 12) and confirm: *the ritual is closer to completion than last session's intel suggested*. Hence the 2-round countdown.

Scene 5 — The Spider Pen

Chamber 2 — The Spider Pen

A 20 × 40 ft. side chamber separated from the antechamber by a curtain of spider-silk. **1× Giant Spider** is chained to the wall — Khelziir's pet sentinel.

- If the silk curtain is disturbed, the spider **shrieks** (a Vhaeraunian-trained alarm). Audible throughout the dungeon.
- Cutting the chain releases the spider; it does not distinguish friend from foe.
- The pen's far wall has a **second crawl-tunnel** sloping down into the dark — this is the route the Lolthite raid party will use in Scene 7. The party can spot it on **DC 14 Perception** while in the pen and may attempt to block, ward, or trap it (a trip-wire, *spike growth*, *entangle*, or simply Kto with a longbow on overwatch). **A blocked tunnel delays the Crash by one round but does not prevent it.**

Scene 6 — The Shrine

Chamber 3 — The Shrine

A 40 × 50 ft. chamber. A black basalt slab altar at the back, draped with a Vhaeraunian half-mask banner. A **partially-consecrated portal anchor** sits at the chamber's center: a circle of obsidian shards 8 ft. across, half-inscribed with Undercommon glyphs in luminescent silver ink. Khelziir stands at the altar, mid-ritual; Zeldrazz flanks him. Black candles burn on the altar with greenish flames.

The chamber opens into a vault of cold black stone. At the back, an altar of polished basalt, and standing at it, a slim drow in robes the color of dried blood, his silver half-mask catching the green candle-flame as he turns. To his right, scarred across the cheek, a familiar face — Zeldrazz T'orrl, who sees you, and smiles like a man who has been waiting.

The Boss Encounter

Khelziir Aun'velve — Drow Priest of Vhaeraun. Full statline on the combat tracker. He will not break formation from the altar — finishing the ritual matters more than his own survival. **R1:** *spirit guardians* + bonus-action *shield of faith*. **R2:** *silence* on the loudest caster (likely Yinu or Loric). **R3:** *spiritual weapon* (a black blade) and continues consecrating.

Zeldrazz T'orrl — Returning Antagonist. Drow Elite Warrior reskin. **He has personally targeted Kto** (the PC who delivered the killing-attempt blow last session, confirmed in S1) and will open with poisoned attacks against her. He is protective of Khelziir and will interpose if the priest is engaged in melee.

The Ritual Countdown — 2 Rounds

The countdown is **2 rounds** when the party enters the Shrine (down from 3 last session — Khelziir has had an extra night). Each round Khelziir is alive, conscious, and not silenced or stunned, the countdown ticks down by one. If it reaches zero, the **portal anchor activates** and **4× Vhaeraunian Drow reinforcements** step through on the next initiative. The encounter escalates from Hard to Deadly.

The party can stop the countdown by:

- Killing Khelziir
- Knocking him unconscious
- Silencing him for a full round (he can step out — only delays)
- Destroying the half-finished anchor itself: **AC 12, 40 HP, vulnerable to bludgeoning** — but striking it provokes opportunity attacks from anyone in melee with the striker, and Khelziir treats it as an attack on himself

Encounter Math

Combatant	CR	XP
Khelziir Aun'velve (Vhaeraun priest)	6	2,300
Zeldrazz T'orrl (drow elite warrior)	5	1,800
2× Drow Scout (from antechamber, if alerted)	1/4	100
Giant Spider (if released from pen)	1	200
Subtotal — Hard for 5×L5	—	~4,400
4× Vhaeraunian Drow reinforcements (if portal opens)	1/4	+1,000
Total — Deadly if anchor activates	—	~5,400

Scene 7 — The Lolthite Crash

Trigger

Round 4 of the Shrine fight, OR if the party stalls at the cleft for more than two rounds without engaging. Use whichever comes first. If the party blocked the crawl-tunnel in the Spider Pen, delay one round.

What Happens

3× Lolthite Drow Raiders burst up out of the crawl-tunnel into the Spider Pen and from there into the antechamber. Spider-emblem shields, webbed cloaks, two curved blades each. They are not subtle. They are here to close another surface mouth.

Faction Behavior

- **The Vhaeraunians prioritize the Lolthites over the party.** Khelziir will break ritual to *bane* or *spirit guardians* the Lolthites; Zeldrazz interposes between the Lolthite line and the altar. Any Vhaeraunian reinforcements that have already stepped through the portal turn on the Lolthites first.

- **The Lolthites prioritize the anchor over the party.** They are here to smash it. If the anchor is still intact when they arrive, they ignore the PCs to bullrush the altar.
- **The party can take advantage of the chaos** — slip out, finish off Khelziir while the Lolthites engage Zeldrazz, smash the anchor themselves under cover, or simply withdraw with whatever they've already grabbed.

What This Means (DM-facing)

The Lolthites learn the surface party exists. Up until now, the Lolthites have only known about Vhaeraunians and dales militia. After the Crash, regardless of the encounter's outcome, the Lolthite enclave under Old Skull has a description of the party. This is a **major loose end** — flag it for the session log.

If the Crash *doesn't* trigger (party finishes the Shrine in three rounds), the Lolthites still come up the crawl-tunnel, but they arrive to find dead Vhaeraunians and no party. They do not yet know the surface party exists. **Reward speed.**

Encounter Math (Crash Alone)

Combatant	CR	XP
3× Lolthite Drow Raider	1	600
Total	—	~600 (pressure-valve, not a fresh encounter)

Scene 8 — Three Endings

How the party leaves the Shrine determines the political shape of the next two sessions.

Ending 1 — Smash the Anchor (Loud Win)

The portal collapses inward in a thunderclap of cold air. Khelziir's cell is permanently shut down; the cleft is no longer usable as a Vhaeraunian staging site. Lady Ulphor is delighted; the militia get credit publicly; the Vhaeraunians know the surface knows.

- **Reputation:** +Lady Ulphor, +Corwick (publicly — see Scene 9), +militia
- **Loose end:** A furious Vhaeraunian retaliation arrives in 2–3 weeks. Form unknown to the party.

Ending 2 — Steal the Anchor for Study (Quiet Win)

Requires a successful **DC 16 Arcana** check by Yinu or Loric to disrupt the consecration without triggering the portal. The anchor goes back to Lady Ulphor, who hands it to Orvyn Tal for Harper analysis.

- **Reputation:** +Harpers significantly, +Lady Ulphor privately, neutral publicly
- **Loose end:** Vhaeraunian retaliation still arrives in 2–3 weeks; they don't know the anchor was taken cleanly until they try to use it from the other side

Ending 3 — Turn It Into a Feed (Clever Win)

If a PC succeeds on a **DC 18 Religion or Arcana** check after Khelziir falls, they realize the half-finished anchor can be left running as a one-way listening glyph into the Vhaeraunian command structure. Orvyn Tal pays handsomely (**+500 gp Harper bounty**) and offers Harper recruitment for this.

- **Reputation:** +Harpers heavily; the Vhaeraunians don't know they're being listened to — yet
- **Loose end:** Vhaeraunian retaliation still arrives in 2–3 weeks; the Harpers will hear it coming first

Withdrawing Without an Ending

If the party flees mid-fight, the Shrine continues consecrating overnight and the portal opens fully. The Lolthite Crash (whether it triggered or not) will eventually purge the cell — but at the cost of Lolthites holding the surface anchor, which is **strictly worse** for Shadowdale than either faction holding it. Lady Ulphor will not say this out loud. She will pay the scouting fee and not the bonus.

Scene 9 — Debrief at the Ashaba House

Setup

Late afternoon, the day after the cleft. Lady Ulphor's working room. Brynn Ashford is present and taking notes; Orvyn Tal arrives later, summoned or not depending on the party's earlier choice.

The "Who Reports First" Beat

- **If the party went to Brynn first** (per his letter): Brynn is satisfied. He shares one piece of Council intelligence in return — *"Mistledale is going to formally raise the question of Cormyrian protection at next month's Council. Lady Ulphor is going to vote against. I would like to know whether you think she's right."* This is a future-session hook; no answer required tonight.
- **If the party went to Orvyn first** (or both, transparently): Orvyn warms perceptibly. He drops his cover — admits Harper affiliation if not already known — and offers the party a standing dead-drop arrangement at the bookshop. Brynn's expression goes flat for a moment and recovers. He will remember.
- **If the party reported only to Lady Ulphor:** both Brynn and Orvyn will follow up privately within the week. The party can defer the choice — but Brynn's letter does not get easier the longer it sits.

The Corwick Reconciliation

Lady Ulphor mentions, almost in passing, that **Captain Helm came to her two nights ago**. They spoke for an hour. He has accepted a private apology from Fiorn (which Fiorn did not actually offer — Lady Ulphor brokered it) and will continue as militia captain. He is **less hostile now**, but the party should understand: *"This cost me something to arrange. I would prefer not to have to do it again."*

She doesn't say what it cost her. **(DM: it cost her a private commitment to Brynn — she has authorized him to make a small Council commitment on Shadowdale's behalf without prior approval. Brynn knows. Fiorn doesn't.)**

Payments

- **300 gp scouting payment** (the half Lady Ulphor would have paid regardless of outcome)
- **300 gp neutralize bonus** (paid only if Site C is closed, by any of the three endings — *not* paid if the party withdrew without resolving the anchor)
- Sela Wyndmere's herbal kit replenished (3× healing poultices, 2× antitoxin) for the next outing — already paid for
- Khelziir's silver half-mask: **Orvyn Tal 200 gp**, or **Lady Ulphor 100 gp** (party chooses the buyer)
- Anchor disposition payments per the chosen ending (see Scene 8 / Treasure section)

Milestone

Advance the party to Level 6 at session end. Inform players before they leave the table — the level-up can be done between sessions.

DM Notes — Debrief Tone

- Lady Ulphor is warmer than at the briefing. She sits when she speaks, instead of standing.
- Brynn is sharper than at the briefing. He is taking more notes than usual.
- Orvyn, if present, is happier than the party has ever seen him. He buys the round at the Old Skull Inn afterward.

NPCs in Play

NPC	Source	Role This Session
Lady Addee Ulphor	Roster	Cold-open isn't with her; debriefs at session end; reports Corwick reconciliation
Brynn Ashford	Roster	Sends the cold-open letter to Loric; pushes for first-call disclosure
Orvyn Tal	Roster	Surfaces at debrief; drops Harper cover if anchor route 2 or 3 chosen
Corwick Helm	Roster	Off-screen this session. Mentioned in debrief; reconciled but bruised
Sela Wyndmere	Roster	Provides poultices/antitoxin in advance; not in any scene directly
Quillip Burr-and-Whistle	Roster (added S3)	Pixie ally at Site C; bargain-broker for intel/diversion/boon
Khelziir Aun'velve	Roster (S2)	Boss — the Vhaeraunian priest, mid-ritual
Zeldrazz T'orrl	Session 001	Returning antagonist — flanks Khelziir, opens on Kto
Aelinor Wains	Session 002	Retired. Mentioned only if the party asks for militia reserve

Treasure & Rewards

- **300 gp scouting + 300 gp neutralize bonus** = 600 gp baseline (bonus contingent on closing Site C)
- **Khelziir's silver half-mask** (Orvyn 200 gp / Lady Ulphor 100 gp)
- ****Spell scroll of *Silence***** (from Khelziir's pouch)
- **Potion of Greater Healing × 2** (Vhaeraunian field stock)
- **Drow poison × 4 vials** (looted from Zeldrazz and the scouts)
- **The portal anchor — ending-dependent:**
- **From the antechamber:** ~30 gp coin · 3× hand crossbows + bolts · the Undercommon ritual journal (Lady Ulphor 50 gp, or Orvyn 100 gp)
- **From the Lolthite raiders (if defeated):** 2× Lolthite signal stones · 1 vial Lolth's-poison (potent: DC 14 CON or poisoned 1 hr) · ~40 gp coin
- **Milestone:** Advance party to **Level 6** at session end

Loose Ends This Session Sets Up

- **Lolthites now know the surface party exists** — *if* the Crash triggered. Major escalation for Sessions 4+
- **Vhaeraunian retaliation in 2–3 weeks** regardless of ending — form depends on ending chosen
- **Brynn vs. Orvyn first-call** sharpens or resolves per anchor disposition; the loser remembers
- **Zeldrazz T'orrl** — if he survives a third encounter, he becomes a confirmed personal nemesis arc (Kto's grudge-mate)
- **Quillip's bargain-cost** — if banked or unpaid, comes due in a future session exactly as stated
- **Sela's "consultations"** — still unfollowed-up. S004 candidate
- **Lady Ulphor's "cost" to reconcile Corwick** — Brynn now has a small unauthorized Council commitment in his pocket; he knows; the party doesn't

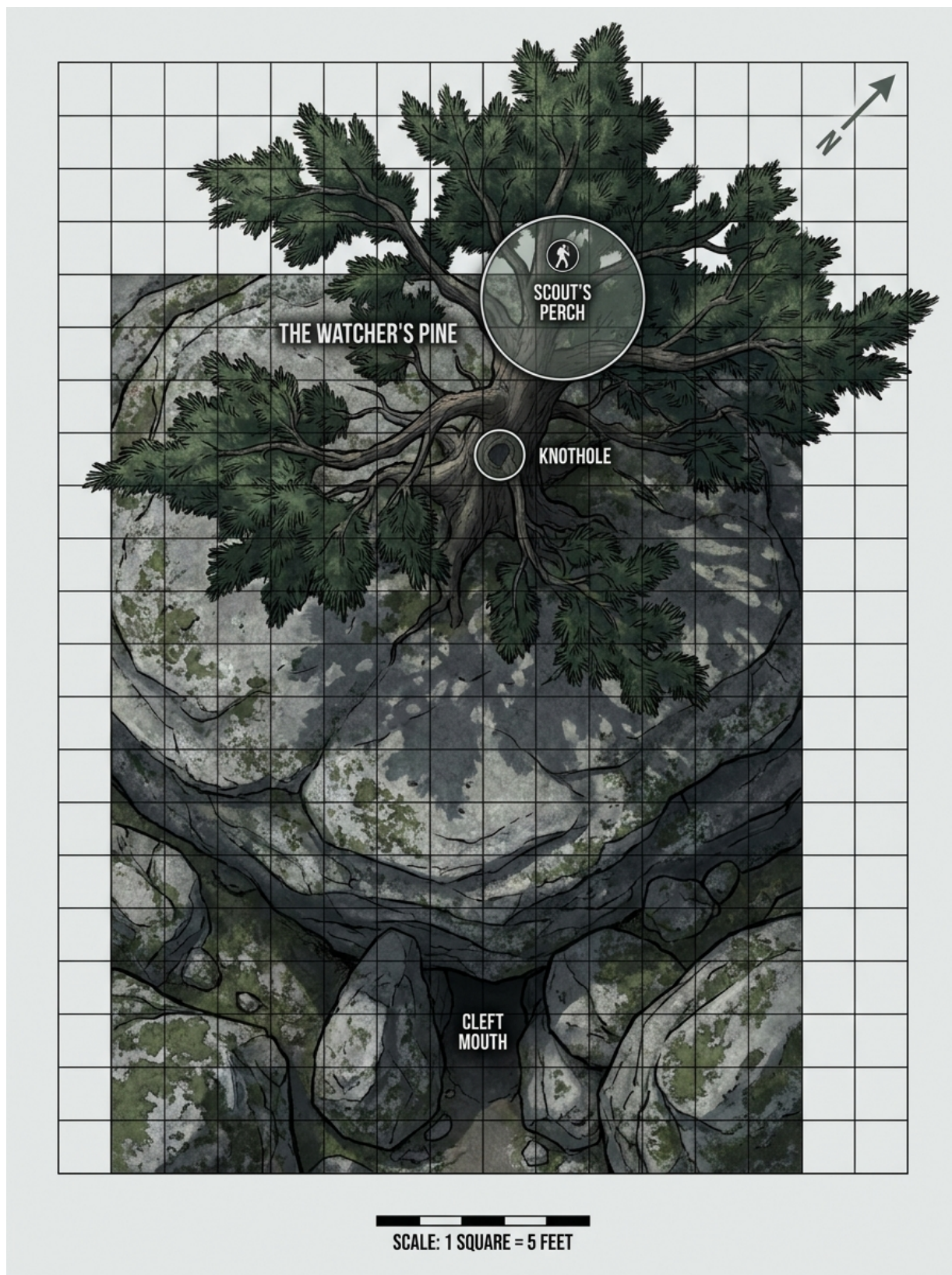
DM Combat Tracker — The Half-Mask Shrine

Printable per-encounter sheets and stat-block cards. HP boxes = 5 HP each (cross out as damage is dealt). Spell-slot boxes = one per slot at that level.

Conditions reference: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Encounter 1 — The Watcher Above

Session 003, Scene 3 · Trivial (skill encounter — DC 17 group Stealth, optional Quillip bargain)



Field	Detail
Location	Wind-stunted pine 60 ft. above the cleft mouth, Site C
Light	Late afternoon to dusk; deep shadow at the cleft mouth
Terrain	Watcher elevated in pine; Quillip's knothole 15 ft. below her

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

Initiative & Damage

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
14	Drow Scout (Watcher)	15	13 ☐ ☐ ☐	Elevated cover, brass signal horn
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Triggers & Countdowns

- DC 17 Perception to spot her before she spots the party (DC 15 if Quillip whistled)
- If she sees them first, she blows the brass signal horn on her turn
- **If horn sounds → Khelziir's cell goes to alert; antechamber scouts ready, one sprints to warn Khelziir**
- Quillip Burr-and-Whistle reveals from her knothole if a PC investigates the trunk (DC 12 Perception) or hails politely

Concentration / Ongoing Effects

Tactics Summary

- **Drow Scout (Watcher)** — Blow horn first. Hand crossbow from elevation. Will not engage in melee.
- **Quillip (non-combatant)** — Will not fight. Offers intel / *phantasmal force* diversion / banked single-use boon.

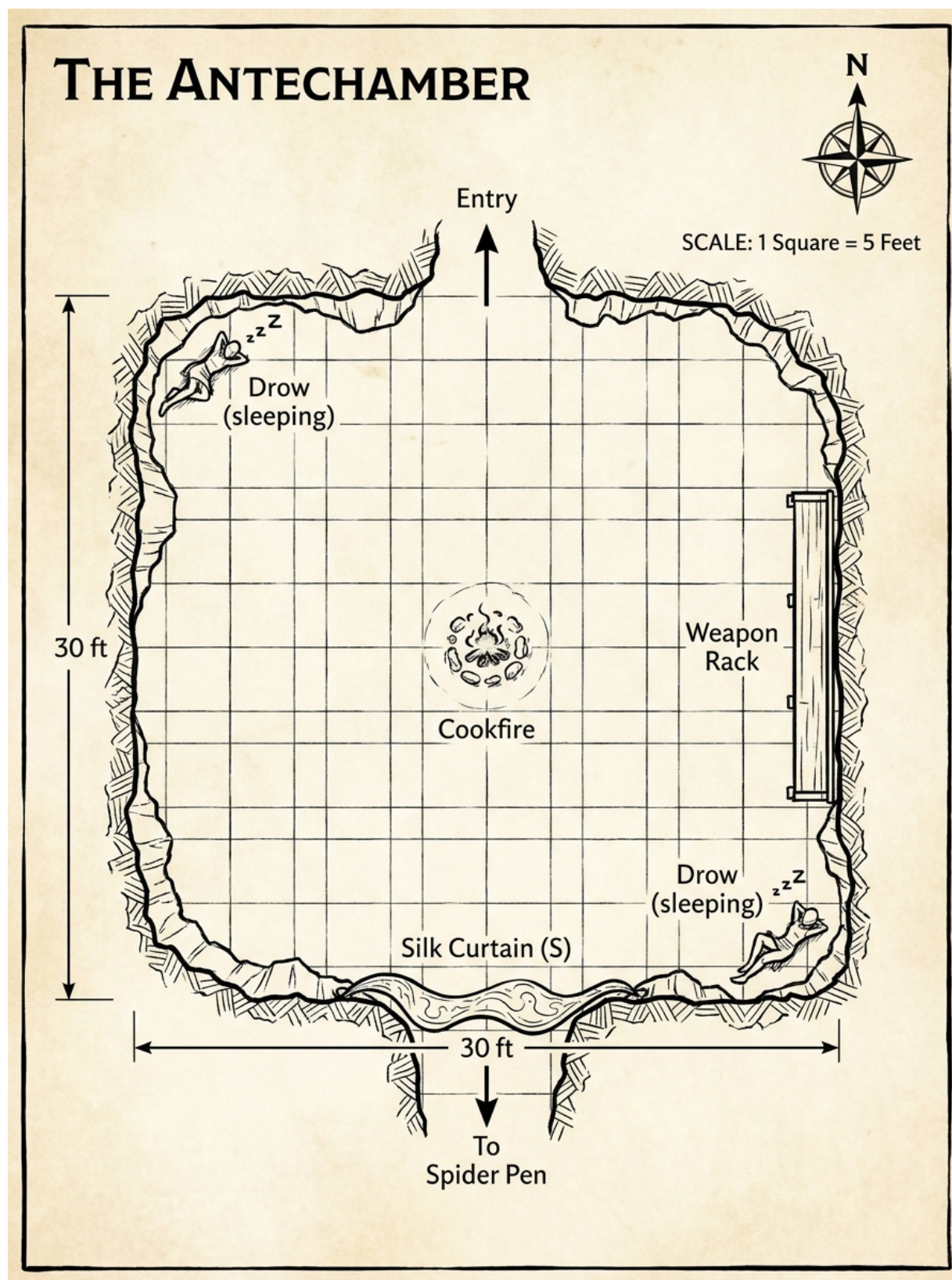
Loot / Aftermath

Brass signal horn (key item) · Hand crossbow + 10 bolts · Drow poison ×1 · ~5 gp

Notes (resources spent · persisting conditions · XP awarded)

Encounter 2 — The Antechamber

Session 003, Scene 4 · Easy (~200 XP)



Field	Detail
Location	Chamber 1, Site C shrine-camp
Light	Cookfire (dim); deeper dark beyond the silk curtain into the Spider Pen
Terrain	30 × 30 ft. natural cavern. Cookfire center; weapon rack east wall; silk curtain to Spider Pen south

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

Initiative & Damage

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
11	Drow Scout A (fletching)	15	13 □□□	Fletching at start; closest to weapon rack
11	Drow Scout B (dozing)	15	13 □□□	Dozing at start; sprints to Shrine to warn if not dropped R1
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Triggers & Countdowns

- If horn from Encounter 1 sounded: both scouts crossbow-ready, surprise denied
- If party kept stealth: surprise round on both
- **Scout B will sprint to the Shrine on her turn if alive** — adds Khelziir alert (he gets 1 free preparatory action when fight begins in Shrine)
- Kicking the cookfire over: scatters embers, opens line of sight into Spider Pen silk curtain

Concentration / Ongoing Effects

Tactics Summary

- **Scout A** — Grabs hand crossbow from rack, fights from cover behind cookfire.
- **Scout B** — Sprints to Shrine on her turn to warn Khelziir. Crossbow only if cornered.

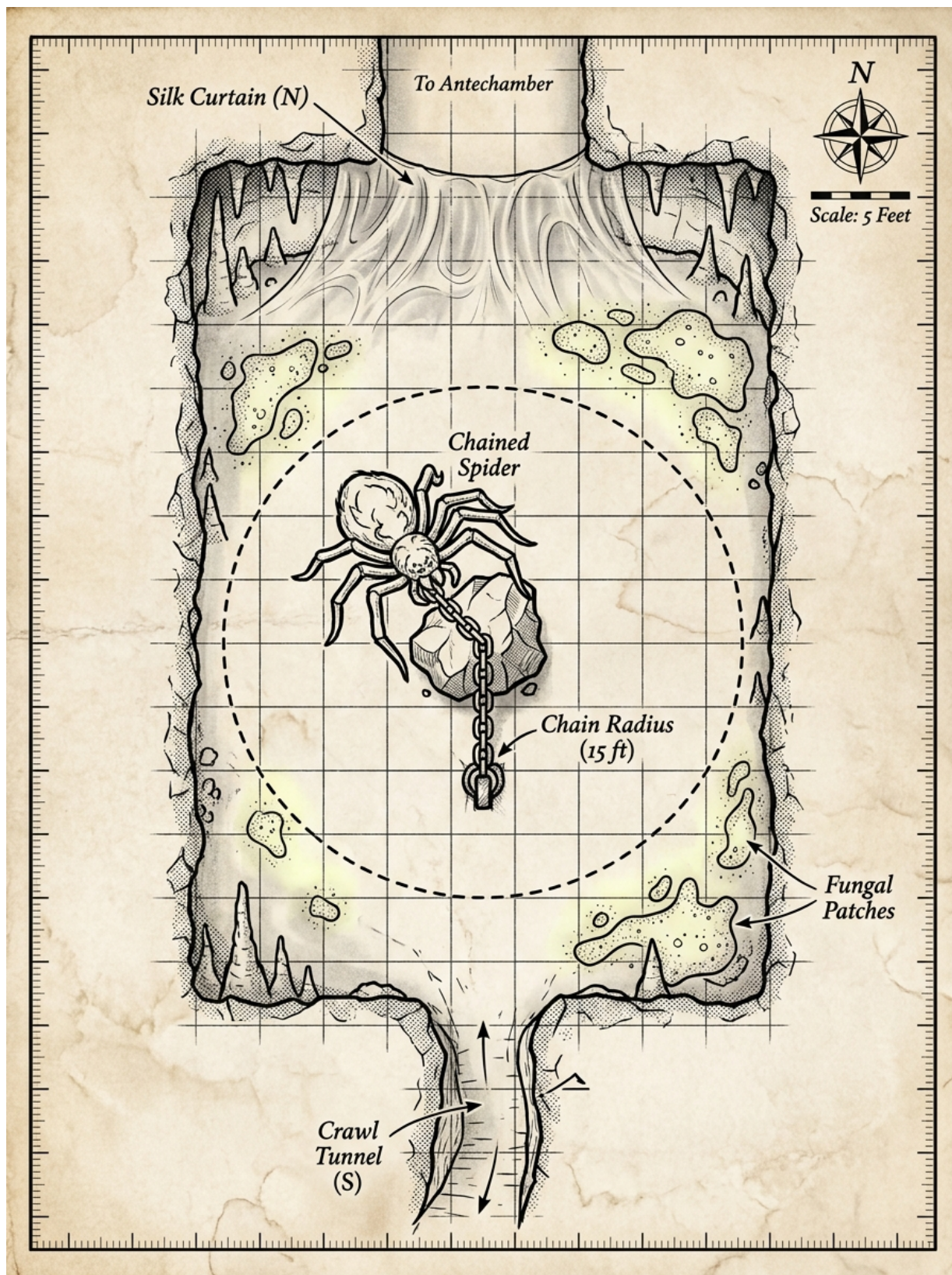
Loot / Aftermath

3× hand crossbows + bolts (rack) · 2× drow poison vials · ~30 gp coin · Undercommon ritual journal (Lady Ulphor 50 gp / Orvyn 100 gp)

Notes (resources spent · persisting conditions · XP awarded)

Encounter 3 — The Spider Pen

Session 003, Scene 5 · Easy (~200 XP). Optional — only if silk curtain disturbed or chain cut



Field	Detail
Location	Chamber 2, Site C shrine-camp
Light	Dark; bioluminescent fungal patches give dim light at floor level
Terrain	20 × 40 ft. side chamber. Silk curtain north (to antechamber). Chained spider mid-chamber. Crawl-tunnel south wall, sloping down.

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

Initiative & Damage

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
10	Giant Spider (chained)	14	26 □□□□□□	Chain reach 15 ft. Released = no friend/foe distinction.
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Triggers & Countdowns

- **Silk curtain disturbed** = **spider shrieks** (Vhaeraunian-trained alarm). Audible throughout dungeon — Khelziir alerted.
- Cutting the chain (AC 16, 10 HP, vuln. slashing) releases the spider; will attack nearest target regardless.
- **Crawl-tunnel south wall** = Lolthite Crash entry route. DC 14 Perception to spot. Can be blocked (delays Crash by 1 round) but not prevented.

Concentration / Ongoing Effects

Tactics Summary

- **Giant Spider** — Bite anything in reach. Web-shoots fleeing targets. Pursues until killed.

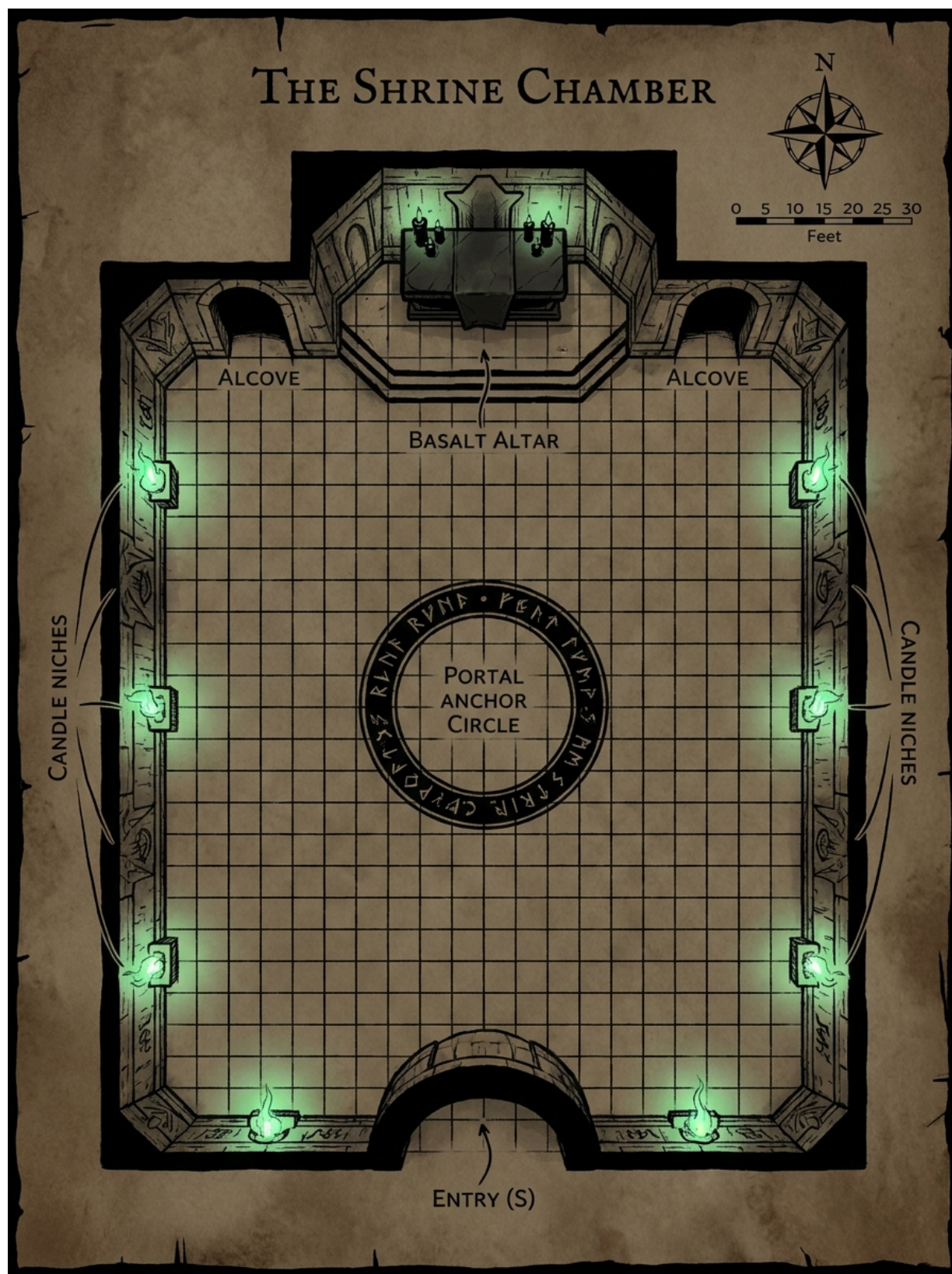
Loot / Aftermath

— (no loot from spider; tunnel intel is the prize)

Notes (resources spent · persisting conditions · XP awarded)

Encounter 4 — The Shrine — Khelziir's Last Ritual

Session 003, Scene 6 · Hard for 5×L5 (~4,400 XP). Becomes Deadly if the portal opens.



Field	Detail
Location	Chamber 3, Site C shrine-camp
Light	Black candles, greenish flames — dim throughout.
Terrain	40 × 50 ft. Basalt altar at back. 8-ft obsidian portal-anchor circle at center.

Round: ☐1 ☐2 ☐3 ☐4 ☐5 ☐6 ☐7 ☐8 ☐9 ☐10

Ritual Countdown (2 rounds): 1 →
 ☒ P
 ☐ ORT
 ☐ AL
 ☐ OPE
 ☐ NS

Initiative & Damage

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
14	Zeldrazz T'orrl	18	71 	Drow Elite Warrior reskin. Targets Kto.
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
13	Khelziir Aun'velve	16	78 	Will not break formation from altar
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
10	Vhaeraunian Drow ×4 (reinforcements)	15	13 ea 	Only if countdown hits 0
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Portal Anchor object:

Triggers & Countdowns

- **RITUAL COUNTDOWN: 2 rounds.** Stop = kill/KO Khelziir, full-round silence (he can step out — only delays), or destroy anchor.
- Striking the anchor provokes opportunity attacks from anyone in melee with the striker. Khelziir treats it as an attack on himself.
- If countdown reaches 0: 4× Vhaeraunian drow step through on the next initiative count 10. Encounter escalates from Hard to Deadly.
- **Lolthite Crash trigger:** Round 4 of this fight, OR party stalled at cleft >2 rounds. Blocked tunnel = +1 round delay.

Concentration / Ongoing Effects

Tactics Summary

- **Khelziir Aun'velve** — R1 *spirit guardians* + BA *shield of faith*. R2 *silence* on loudest caster (Yinu/Loric). R3 *spiritual weapon* (black blade), continue ritual. Will not leave altar.
- **Zeldrazz T'orrl** — Opens with poisoned attacks vs. Kto (S1 grudge). Protective of Khelziir — will interpose. Will not retreat.
- **Vhaeraunian Drow ×4** — Step through portal next initiative. Form line in front of Khelziir. Fight to the death.

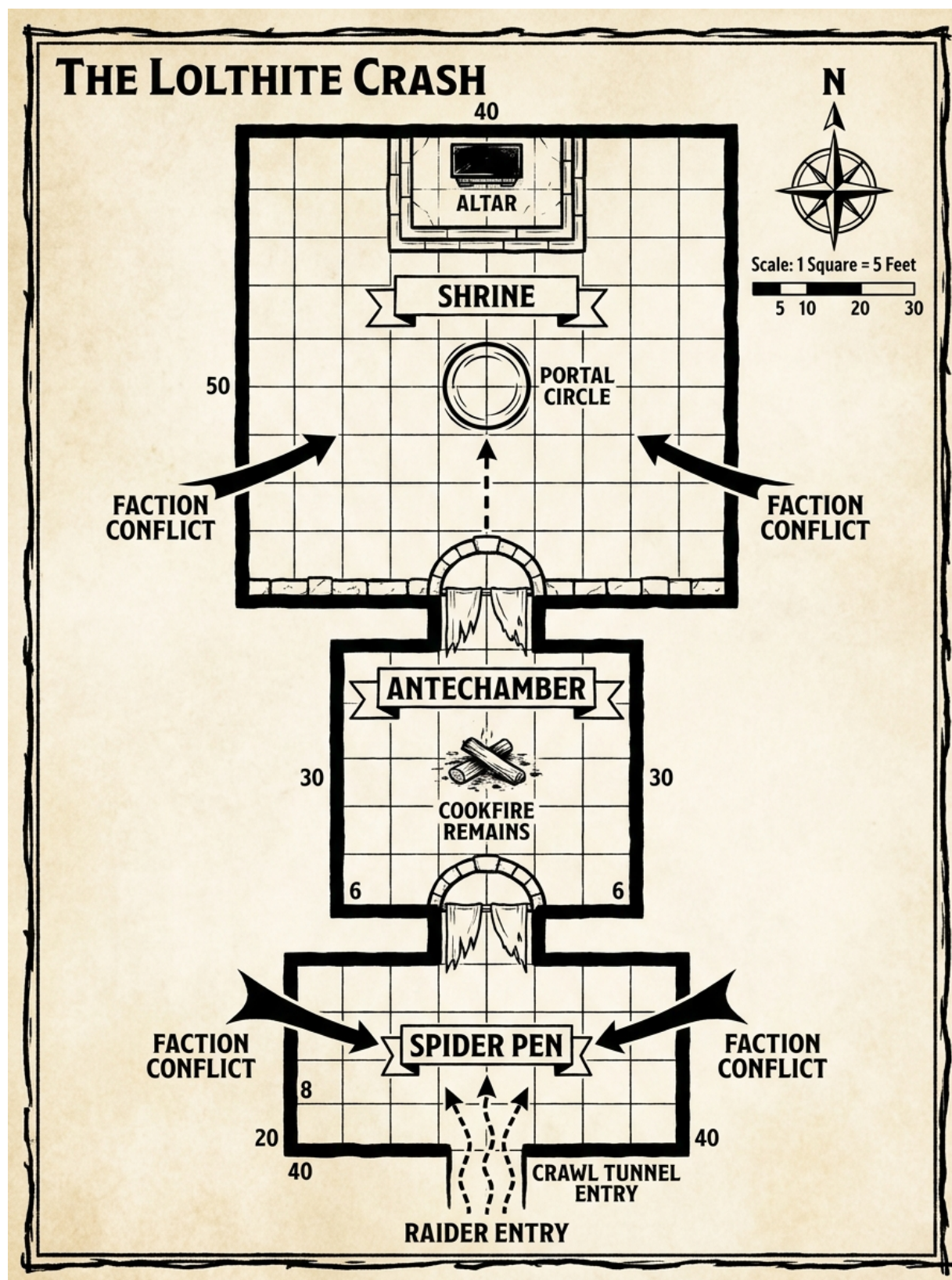
Loot / Aftermath

Khelziir's silver half-mask (Orvyn 200 gp / Ulphor 100 gp) · Spell scroll of *Silence* · Greater Healing potion ×2 · Drow poison ×4 vials · The portal anchor (ending-dependent — see adventure Scene 8)

Notes (resources spent · persisting conditions · XP awarded)

Encounter 5 — The Lolthite Crash

Session 003, Scene 7 · ~600 XP (pressure-valve, not a fresh encounter)



Notes (resources spent · persisting conditions · XP awarded)

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Stat Cards

Reference cards for every non-PC combatant in the encounters above. Reprinted in full so the DM doesn't need to flip back during the fight.

Drow Scout

Medium humanoid (elf), neutral evil · CR 1/2 (100 XP)

AC	HP	Speed
15 (studded leather)	13 (3d8)	30 ft.

STR 10 · **DEX** 14 · **CON** 10 · **INT** 11 · **WIS** 13 · **CHA** 12

Skills Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5 · Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 15 · Languages Elvish, Undercommon

Traits

Fey Ancestry — adv. on saves vs. charmed; immune to magical sleep.

Sunlight Sensitivity — disadv. on attack & Perception (sight) in sunlight.

Innate Spellcasting (1/day each — strike when used): [] dancing lights · [] darkness · [] faerie fire.

Actions

Multiattack — 2× shortsword OR 2× hand crossbow.

Shortsword — +4 to hit, 1d6+2 piercing.

Hand Crossbow — +4 to hit, 30/120 ft., 1d6+2 piercing + drow poison (DC 13 CON or unconscious 1 hr; ends if damaged).

Tactics — Crossbow from cover. Drops shortsword for stealth retreat if outmatched. Watcher blows horn first; antechamber dozer sprints to warn Khelziir.

Loot — Hand crossbow · 10 bolts · Drow poison ×1 · 5 gp

Giant Spider

Large beast, unaligned · CR 1 (200 XP)

AC	HP	Speed
14 (natural armor)	26 (4d10+4)	30 ft., climb 30 ft.

STR 14 · **DEX** 16 · **CON** 12 · **INT** 2 · **WIS** 11 · **CHA** 4

Skills Stealth +7 · Senses blindsight 10 ft., darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10 · MM p.328

Traits

Spider Climb — including ceilings.

Web Sense — knows location of anything in contact with the same web.

Web Walker — ignores movement restrictions from webbing.

Actions

Bite — +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., 1d8+3 piercing + 2d8 poison (DC 11 CON half; if reduced to 0 HP, stable but poisoned and paralyzed for 1 hr).

Web (Recharge 5-6) — 30/60 ft. ranged, DC 11 DEX or restrained; AC 10, 5 HP, vuln. fire/slash.

Tactics — Bites whatever's in chain reach. Once chain is cut, pursues the closest soft target. Will not distinguish friend from foe.

Loot — —

Khelziir Aun'velve — Drow Priest of Vhaeraun

Medium humanoid (drow), neutral evil · CR 6 (2,300 XP)

AC	HP	Speed
16 (chain shirt + shield of faith)	78 (12d8+24)	30 ft.

STR 11 · **DEX** 14 · **CON** 14 · **INT** 13 · **WIS** 17 · **CHA** 14

Saves WIS +6, CHA +5 · Skills Perception +6, Religion +4, Stealth +5 · Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 16
· Languages Common, Elvish, Undercommon

Traits

Fey Ancestry, Sunlight Sensitivity.

Innate Spellcasting (1/day each — strike when used): [] faerie fire · [] darkness · [] levitate.

Spellcasting (cleric, save DC 14, +6 to hit)

Cantrips: guidance, sacred flame, thaumaturgy

1st ([] [] []): bane, command, shield of faith

2nd ([] [] []): silence, spiritual weapon

3rd ([] [] []): dispel magic, spirit guardians

4th ([]): banishment

Actions

Multiattack — 2× shortsword.

Shortsword — +5 to hit, 1d6+2 piercing + 1d6 poison.

Hand Crossbow — +5 to hit, 30/120 ft., 1d6+2 + drow poison (DC 13 CON or unconscious 1 hr).

Tactics — R1 *spirit guardians* + BA *shield of faith*. R2 *silence* on loudest caster. R3 *spiritual weapon*, continue ritual.
Will not leave altar. If Lolthite Crash arrives, breaks ritual to *bane/spirit guardians* the raiders.

Loot — Silver half-mask (200 gp) · Spell scroll of Silence · 2× Greater Healing potions

Zeldrazz T'orrl — Drow Elite Warrior (reskinned)

Medium humanoid (drow), neutral evil · CR 5 (1,800 XP)

AC	HP	Speed
18 (chain shirt + shield)	71 (13d8+13)	30 ft.

STR 14 · **DEX** 18 · **CON** 13 · **INT** 11 · **WIS** 13 · **CHA** 12

Saves DEX +7, CON +4, WIS +4 · Skills Perception +4, Stealth +7 · Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 14 · MM p.128

Traits

Fey Ancestry, Sunlight Sensitivity.

Innate Spellcasting (1/day each — strike when used): [] dancing lights · [] darkness · [] faerie fire · [] levitate.

Actions

Multiattack — 2× shortsword (one as bonus action — see below).

Shortsword — +7 to hit, 1d6+4 piercing + 3d6 poison (DC 13 CON half) + 2d6 poison (DC 13 CON or poisoned 1 min, retry each end of turn).

Hand Crossbow — +7 to hit, 30/120 ft., 1d6+4 + drow poison (DC 13 CON or unconscious 1 hr).

Reactions

Parry — +3 AC vs. one melee attack he can see, must be wielding a melee weapon.

Tactics — Opens with poisoned attacks vs. **Kto** (S1 grudge). Protective of Khelziir — will interpose if priest is engaged in melee. Will not retreat. If Khelziir falls, fights to the death covering the anchor.

Loot — Plain steel scimitar · 2× drow poison vials · cracked half-mask trophy

Vhaeraunian Drow (reinforcement)

Medium humanoid (elf), neutral evil · CR 1/4 (50 XP)

AC	HP	Speed
15 (chain shirt)	13 (3d8)	30 ft.

STR 10 · **DEX** 14 · **CON** 10 · **INT** 11 · **WIS** 11 · **CHA** 12

Skills Perception +2, Stealth +4 · Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 12 · Standard Drow, MM p.128

Traits

Fey Ancestry, Sunlight Sensitivity, Innate Spellcasting (1/day each: dancing lights, darkness, faerie fire).

Actions

Shortsword — +4 to hit, 1d6+2 piercing.

Hand Crossbow — +4 to hit, 30/120 ft., 1d6+2 + drow poison (DC 13 CON or unconscious 1 hr).

Tactics — Step through the portal. Form a line in front of Khelziir. Fight to the death. Prioritize Lolthites if Crash has triggered.

Loot — Standard Drow loadout (deconstruct ×4)

Lolthite Drow Raider

Medium humanoid (elf), chaotic evil · CR 1 (200 XP)

AC	HP	Speed
16 (studded leather + shield)	39 (6d8+12)	30 ft.

STR 12 · DEX 16 · CON 14 · INT 11 · WIS 13 · CHA 12

Skills Perception +3, Stealth +7 · Senses darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 13 · Languages Elvish, Undercommon

Traits

Fey Ancestry, Sunlight Sensitivity.

Innate Spellcasting (1/day each — strike when used): [] dancing lights · [] darkness · [] faerie fire.

Spider's Favor — adv. on saves vs. poison; immune to webbing restraint.

Actions

Multiattack — 2× scimitar.

Scimitar (curved blade) — +5 to hit, 1d6+3 slashing + 1d6 poison (Lolth's-poison; DC 14 CON or poisoned 1 min, retry end of turn).

Hand Crossbow — +5 to hit, 30/120 ft., 1d6+3 + drow poison (DC 13 CON or unconscious 1 hr).

Reactions

Spider Step — When missed by a melee attack, may move 5 ft. without provoking opportunity attacks.

Tactics — **Smash the anchor first.** Ignore PCs unless engaged. Prioritize Vhaeraunians over PCs once anchor is destroyed. Retreat down crawl-tunnel if reduced below ¼ HP — this is the **major loose end** that tells the Lolthite enclave a surface party exists.

Loot — Spider-emblem shield (10 gp curio) · 2× scimitars · 1 vial Lolth's-poison · ~13 gp

Where We Left Off



Site B is rubble. You burned a wounded drider and two giant spiders in the chimney shaft and pulled a half-burnt scroll from the fire — *"Close the surface mouths. The Vhaeraun is opening."* — Lolthite handwriting. The cleft itself was sealed by drow magic.

Two drow factions are at war below your feet — Lolth's people slamming doors shut, Vhaeraun's prying them open. You slept in the wreckage of someone else's purge, and nobody came looking. **Site C is still open.** It's four hours north along the granite shoulder, and you are the only ones who know exactly where it is.

This morning, **Loric found a folded letter in his pack** — sealed with the thistle-and-ash sigil of Shadowdale, in Brynn Ashford's hand. He doesn't remember it being there when he went to sleep.

What Now?

- **Four hours north** along the granite shoulder to **Site C** — the last open cleft.
- **Watch for tracks.** Three sets of boot-scuffs in the lichen, moving uphill toward Site C from a different angle than yours. Someone else may be moving today.
- **The letter is Loric's to share, sit on, or burn.**

Cold Camp at the Hawthorn Chimney



The Half-Mask Shrine — Vhaeraunian Altar, Site C



Brynn Ashford — Shadowdale's Delegate to the Dales Council



Brynn's Letter

Found the morning of the trek to Site C — a folded paper tucked into Loric's pack, sealed with the thistle-and-ash sigil of Shadowdale. No signature. It was not in his pack when he went to sleep. It was in it when he woke.

Where You Know Him From

Lean man in his early thirties. Ink-stained fingers — he writes everything down. Thistle-and-ash badge pinned at the collar of a clean leather doublet. Speaks for **Lady Ulphor** at the Dales Council in Ashabenford and is currently quartered in Shadowdale.

You met him at the briefing in Lady Ulphor's working room before you rode for the Hawthorn Chimney. After the meeting broke, he pulled **Loric** aside privately and revealed — quietly, and without Lady Ulphor's blessing — that **Orvyn Tal is a Harper**. He asked the party to bring its findings to him *before* the Harpers, with a vague offer of "incentivity." Loric made no promise.

*Whatever you find at the third site, I want a sketch and a number before Orvyn does.
I am not asking you to lie to him.
I am asking you to choose the door you knock on first.*

The Watcher Above — Drow Scout in the Pine, Quillip's Knothole Below



Quillip Burr-and-Whistle — Pixie Ally at the Watcher Above



The Cleft Mouth — Site C Entrance



The Shrine Chamber — Site C Interior



Khelziir Aun'velve — Drow Priest of Vhaeraun



Zeldrazz T'orrl — Drow Elite Warrior, Demoted



The Lolthite Crash — Three Raiders Erupting Into the Antechamber



Lolthite Drow — Elite Raider of Lolth



Lady Ulphor — Keeper of the Pendant of Ashaba



DM Quick Reference — The Half-Mask Shrine

Session 003 · Print and keep at the table · Full detail in file 1

Scene Order

#	Scene	Key mechanic	DM flag
1	Cold Camp	Inventory beat · Brynn's letter to Loric	Don't push the letter — if Loric pockets it, that's fine
2	Northern Traverse	Survival/Nature DC 13 (lead PC); optional track-sign DC 14 Survival	Fail = PCs arrive at dusk, ½ HD pool until short rest
3	Watcher Above	DC 17 Perception to spot watcher · Quillip bargain	Horn blown → antechamber scouts go alert
4	Antechamber	2× Drow Scouts · Scout B sprints to Shrine if alive	Cookfire kick = embers + LoS into Spider Pen silk
5	Spider Pen	Giant Spider alarm if silk disturbed · Crawl-tunnel south wall	DC 14 Perception to spot tunnel; blocking delays Crash by 1 round
6	The Shrine	BOSS — 2-round ritual countdown	See countdown rules below
7	Lolthite Crash	Round 4 of Shrine fight (or stall >2 rounds at cleft)	Lolthites saw the party = enclave learns they exist
8	Three Endings	Smash / Steal / Feed → different rep + retaliation	Ending 1 loud, Ending 3 silent, all trigger retaliation timer
9	Debrief	Ashaba House · Who reports first? · Level-up	Lady Ulphor sits this time — warmer tone

Ritual Countdown

Starts at 2 when the party enters the Shrine. Ticks down by 1 each round Khelziir is alive, conscious, and **not** silenced or stunned.

How to stop it	Caveat
Kill or KO Khelziir	—
Silence him for a full round	He can step out of the <i>silence</i> zone to delay (only delays)
Destroy the anchor (AC 12, HP 40, vuln. bludgeoning)	Provokes OAs; Khelziir treats it as an attack on himself

Countdown hits 0 → 4× Vhaeraunian drow step through next initiative (init 10). Hard → Deadly.

Khelziir's Spell Priority

Round	Action	Bonus action
1	<i>spirit guardians</i> (30 ft. radius)	<i>shield of faith</i> (+2 AC)
2	<i>silence</i> on loudest caster (Yinu or Loric)	—
3+	<i>spiritual weapon</i> (black blade) + continue ritual	—
Lolthite Crash arrives	Breaks ritual → <i>bane</i> or <i>spirit guardians</i> vs. Lolthites	—

Khelziir will not leave the altar. Zeldrazz interposes if the priest is engaged in melee.

Zeldrazz's Grudge

Opening target: Kto. Poisoned attacks, Parry reaction (+3 AC). If Khelziir falls, Zeldrazz fights to the death at the anchor.

Lolthite Crash Timing

- **Trigger:** Round 4 of the Shrine fight, OR party stalled at the cleft >2 rounds without engaging (whichever is first).
- **Delay:** Blocked Spider Pen tunnel → +1 round.
- **Faction priority — Lolthites:** smash the anchor first; ignore PCs unless engaged.
- **Faction priority — Vhaeraunians:** turn on Lolthites over the party.
- **Major loose end:** any Lolthite escaping alive or getting a good look = enclave learns the surface party exists. Flag it.

Quillip Bargain — Quick Matrix

One boon, one cost per encounter. Quillip picks the cost from the tier column.

Boon	Effect	Cost tier
Intel: Watcher schedule	Blind side, walk arc, horn placement	<i>Cheap</i> — a true secret (small), a verse of a real song, or a token from outside the Dales
Intel: Site C interior	Headcount, rotations, spider alarm, Khelziir's 2-round countdown	<i>Cheap</i> — same tier
Diversion: lure Watcher	<i>phantasmal force</i> → Watcher off-post ~5 min; removes horn risk	<i>Moderate</i> — a binding promise (specific, finite) or a true name not in the party
Banked boon: <i>sleep</i>	5d8 HP, named target within 24 hr, one use	<i>Moderate</i> — same tier
Banked boon: <i>confusion</i>	10-ft. radius, 1 min, WIS save, named target	<i>Steep</i> — page from Yinu's spellbook (in Yinu's hand), true name of someone close to a PC, or a song composed for Quillip in the moment
Banked boon: <i>polymorph</i>	1 hr or concentration drops, named target	<i>Steep</i> — same tier

If stiffed: she returns in a later session, politely, with interest. Do not skip.

If threatened/brushed off: Superior Invisibility, boon gone for this session.

If pressed about Sela's "unnamed fey lord": she goes very still and leaves the conversation.

Three Endings

Ending	How	Reputation	Loose end
1 — Smash (loud win)	Destroy the anchor	+Ulphor, +Corwick (publicly), +militia	Vhaeraunian retaliation in 2–3 weeks (heavy strike)
2 — Steal (quiet win)	DC 16 Arcana by Yinu/Loric to disrupt cleanly; anchor goes to Orvyn	+Harpers (big), +Ulphor (private), neutral publicly	Retaliation in 2–3 weeks; they don't know it was taken cleanly until they try to use it
3 — Feed (clever win)	DC 18 Religion or Arcana after Khelziir falls; turns anchor into a one-way Harper listening glyph	+Harpers (heavy); Orvyn offers recruitment; +500 gp bounty	Retaliation still in 2–3 weeks; Harpers hear it coming first
Withdraw without ending	Flee mid-fight	Scouting fee only; no bonus	Portal fully opens overnight; Lolthites may purge it but then <i>hold</i> the surface anchor — strictly worse for Shadowdale

Debrief Payments (Scene 9)

Item	Condition	Payer	Amount
Scouting payment	Always	Lady Ulphor	300 gp
Neutralize bonus	Any of Endings 1, 2, or 3	Lady Ulphor	300 gp
Khelziir's silver half-mask	Party's choice of buyer	Orvyn Tal	200 gp
		Lady Ulphor	100 gp
Portal anchor (Ending 2)	Stolen for study	Harpers	800 gp
		Lady Ulphor	400 gp
Listening glyph bonus (Ending 3)	Turned into Harper feed	Harpers	+500 gp bounty
Spell scroll of <i>Silence</i>	Looted from Khelziir	—	Keep or sell
Sela Wyndmere's poultice resupply	Pre-paid by Ulphor	—	3× healing poultice, 2× antitoxin
Milestone	Session end	—	Advance party to Level 6

Who Reports First? (Scene 9 outcome)

- **Party → Brynn first:** Brynn is satisfied. Shares one Council intel: *"Mistledale is raising Cormyrian protection at next month's Council. Lady Ulphor votes against. I'd like your read."* Future hook — no answer needed tonight.
- **Party → Orvyn first (or both, transparent):** Orvyn drops his Harper cover if not already known. Offers a standing dead-drop at the bookshop. Brynn's expression goes flat for a moment. He will remember.

- **Party** → **Lady Ulphor only**: both Brynn and Orvyn follow up privately within the week. Choice deferred — but Brynn's letter doesn't get easier.

Corwick Reconciliation Beat (mention in Scene 9)

Lady Ulphor mentions, almost in passing, that **Captain Helm came to her two nights ago**. He has accepted a private apology from Fiorn (which Lady Ulphor brokered — Fiorn didn't actually offer it). He will continue as militia captain, **less hostile now**.

"This cost me something to arrange. I would prefer not to have to do it again."

DM: she authorized Brynn to make a small Council commitment on Shadowdale's behalf without prior approval. Brynn knows. Fiorn doesn't.

Debrief Tone

- **Lady Ulphor**: warmer than the briefing. **Sits** when she speaks. Touches the Pendant of Ashaba twice.
- **Brynn**: sharper. Takes more notes than usual.
- **Orvyn (if present)**: happiest the party has ever seen him. Buys the round at the Old Skull Inn afterward.

Loose Ends to Flag in Session Log After Play

- [] Did any Lolthite see the party clearly / escape alive? → Lolthite enclave learns party exists (major escalation)
- [] Which ending did the party choose? → Retaliation timer: 2–3 weeks, form = ending-dependent
- [] Who did the party report to first? → Brynn vs. Orvyn wedge sharpens or resolves
- [] Did Zeldrizz survive? → 3rd encounter = confirmed personal nemesis arc for Kto
- [] Was Quillip's bargain paid? → Unpaid bargain comes due in a later session
- [] Did the party interact with Sela's "unnamed fey lord" thread? → S004 candidate
- [] Lady Ulphor's "cost" — did the party notice or ask? → Brynn now has a small unauthorized Council commitment